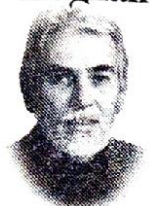


Raptor Center opening a top-flight eagle aviary

LATTA PLANTATION — The woods were dripping and silent and the ground was like a wet sponge underfoot the other day when Bill Veach, Mathius Engelmann and I went out to look at the

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new eagle aviary at the Carolina Raptor Center. Veach is the center's executive director; Engelmann is its rehabilitation coordinator. Both were exhilarated over the \$70,000 aviary, which will eventually house eight to 12 injured or orphaned bald and golden eagles. It opens April 24 with a public dedication, although it's finished now except for landscaping.

What we saw, coming through the woods, was something resembling a huge batting cage, or the net screen behind home plate in a baseball stadium — except that the aviary is four stories high and the netting completely encloses a 25,000-square-foot rectangle the size of two tennis courts laid end-to-end.

Inside this net house are nesting platforms and perches for the eagles, three of whom were already there, preening themselves and staring out over the soggy woodlands as if they owned it. None of them can fly, having suffered various kinds of injuries in their young lives.

The bulk of the money for the new aviary came from the Betty J. and J. Stanley Livingstone Foundation. Duke Energy donated the tall support poles, Sonitrol contributed a high-tech security system, and a raft of businesses and individuals donated labor, materials or money.

The Raptor Center leases 57 acres in Latta Plantation Park, on Sample Road six miles north of downtown Charlotte. Founded in 1979, it's dedicated to environmental education and the rehabilitation of injured and orphaned raptors:

owls, kestrels, osprey, eagles, vultures, hawks and the like.

Its paid staff, 130 volunteers and volunteer veterinarians rehabilitate 500 birds a year. About half of them are released back into the wild. Those that can't be released become part of the educational exhibits.

"Most of the birds we receive come to us as a result of contact with humans," Veach was saying. He meant *unfortunate* contact with humans. About half the birds brought to the center have been wounded by gunshots, struck by cars, poisoned, maimed in traps or shocked by high-tension wires.

Why does federal law protect vultures and hawks? Mainly because they control populations of rodents that, otherwise, would inundate the world, crowding into our homes and stripping the food

from fields.

Interestingly, raptors are at the top of the food chain: They have no natural predators. This, Veach explained, makes them ideal indicators of the harm we do to the environment.

"If we're poisoning our waters, that'll show up in raptors," he said. "Overuse of pesticides some years back nearly wiped out the falcons. Where you see raptors disappearing, you can generally look to mankind for the cause. We're either infringing on their habitats or affecting their food sources."

For 10 years Engelmann and the vets have been working in an old mobile home trailer fitted up as a rehabilitation center. Surgery and routine health maintenance take place there. It's so crowded in the trailer that it's impossible to keep the birds quiet while they're being treated.

But that will soon change. By summer, a new 4,000-square-foot rehab center will be complete, where vets and staff will have space to conduct X-rays and blood tests, clean and bandage wounds, do physical therapy on birds, prepare food, etc. There'll be an operating room, treatment and recovery rooms, a lounge, and a walk-in freezer for food storage. (The food, in this case, is Raptors' Delight: frozen mice.)

Veach and others are soliciting furniture, equipment and supplies for the new building: everything from X-ray developing machines to stainless-steel carts, surgical gauze and rubbing alcohol.

WANT TO HELP?

If you'd like to help with expenses, mail a tax-deductible donation to Veach at the Carolina Raptor Center, P.O. Box 16443, Charlotte, NC 28297.

John Vaughan's column appears every Wednesday and Sunday. If you have a story idea, call him at 358-5228 anytime.